



Skininput—appropriating the body as an input surface

FUTURE OF INTERACTIVE ELECTRONICS

In the future, even touchscreen displays may not be needed. Your skin will double as the input device for electronic devices

■ DR S.S. VERMA

Today, our interaction with most electronic devices is limited to a few functions like switch on/off, timer, sleep mode, and control of light and sound. We are certainly not satisfied with this level of interactivity. We want electronic devices that interact with us just as a virtual personality. The devices should talk, sense, discuss and advise just like another human being.

The electronics industry has already progressed a lot in providing interactive electronic devices such as smartphones and computers with touch-screen control. Universal remotes do away with the need for using different remotes for different

brands or different types of consumer electronics products. Electronic devices are becoming more interconnected through the Internet, WiFi, broadband and Bluetooth.

The aim is to integrate the fields of electronics, new media, architecture and computing to create new environments, interactive installations, devices and live performances, using pre-recorded and live generated material. The journey isn't going to stop at a few advances mentioned here but there'll be much more to see.

Conductive body paint

Imagine your body painted with a specially formulated ink and your gestures, movements or touch allowing you to communicate with electronic

devices directly. The paint acts as a medium to send the information from one person to another, transmit data from a person to a computer, or power small LEDs.

Currently, this technology finds simple applications that consume less power, such as switching and data transfer, but the potential is unlimited. In the future, it can be explored in the areas of dance, music, computer interfaces, communication and medical devices. It will also be useful where wires are cumbersome.

The ink *per-se* is temporary, non-toxic and water-soluble. It is composed of non-metallic conductive particles suspended in food and cosmetic additives. Thus it is safe for skin application. The circuitry between the ink and